

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 7 & 8

CHAPTER 7: EMILY BEFORE

Flashback. September 1976.

The kitchen of the Rose farmhouse didn't just smell of food; it smelled of history. It smelled of yeast that had been rising in the same wooden bowl for twenty years. It smelled of cinnamon, of old coffee grounds, and of the lye soap her mother used to scrub the floorboards until they were white as bone.

Emily Rose stood at the counter, her hands buried to the wrists in dough.

She closed her eyes, letting the rhythm take her.

Push. Turn. Fold.

Push. Turn. Fold.

It was a prayer made of flour and water. It was muscle memory, ingrained in her tendons like the pattern of the seasons.

"You're going to miss this," her mother said.

Maria Rose was standing at the sink, peeling potatoes. The skin of the potatoes curled away in long, brown ribbons, falling into the metal basin with a soft *plip*.

"I can buy bread at the store, Mama," Emily said, opening her eyes. She smiled, but it felt tight. "They have a bakery near campus."

"Store bread," Maria scoffed, not looking up. "Tastes like cardboard. Tastes like nothing. You need good food if you're going to be studying all night. You need strength."

Emily looked down at the dough. It was warm, alive under her hands.

"I'll be fine, Mama. I'm nineteen."

"Nineteen is a baby," Maria said. She turned off the tap. The sudden silence in the kitchen was heavy. The only sound was the wind outside, scratching against the siding like a dog wanting to come in.

"The city is different, Emily," Maria said softly. "It's loud. It's fast. And it's... empty."

"Empty?"

"Spiritually empty. There are too many people and not enough silence for God to speak."

Emily wiped a stray strand of hair from her forehead, leaving a streak of white flour on her skin. She looked out the window.

The fields were turning gold. The corn was high, dry, rustling in the wind. The harvest was coming.

Usually, she would be here for it. She would be helping her father in the barn, the air thick with dust and diesel.

But this year, she wouldn't be here.

She was going to the University. To the city. To the world of books and coffee shops and boys who didn't smell like manure.

It felt like a liberation.

But it also felt... dangerous. Like stepping off a cliff in the dark, trusting that there was water below and not rocks.

She walked to the hallway to wash her hands.

At the end of the hall, there was a small niche in the wall. A shrine.

A statue of the Virgin Mary stood there. It was cheap plaster, painted in bright blues and whites that had faded over the years. A string of plastic rosary beads was draped over her hands. A votive candle flickered in a red glass cup.

Emily stopped.

She always stopped here. It was habit.

She knelt on the worn runner rug. Her knees popped. A sharp, dry crack.

She winced. Her knees had been aching lately. Growing pains? Or something else?

"Hail Mary, full of grace," she whispered.

She didn't pray for good grades. She didn't pray for a boyfriend.

She prayed for... protection.

Why?

She didn't know.

But lately, when the sun went down, the farmhouse didn't feel cozy. It felt sieged.

The wind sounded less like air and more like voices.

Hssssss... Em-i-ly...

She looked up at the statue.

The painted eyes of the Virgin were serene, looking down at her with infinite patience.

But then... the light from the votive candle flickered.

The shadows in the niche jumped.

For a second—just a fraction of a second—it looked like the Virgin's eyes shifted.

Looking past Emily.

Looking over her shoulder.

At the dark corner of the hallway behind her.

Emily froze.

The hair on her arms stood up. The flour on her skin felt suddenly cold, like snow.

She didn't want to turn around.

Every instinct in her body screamed *Don't look.*

But she had to.

She turned her head slowly.

The coat rack stood in the corner.

It was piled high with winter coats. Her father's heavy canvas jacket. Her mother's wool shawl.

In the dim light, the pile of clothes looked like a figure.

A tall, thin man.

Wearing a heavy coat.

And a hat. A wide-brimmed hat that shadowed his face.

He was standing perfectly still. Watching her.

"Daddy?" Emily whispered.

The figure didn't move.

"Daddy, is that you?"

Silence. Just the wind scratching at the walls.

Emily stood up. Her heart was hammering against her ribs like a trapped bird.

She took a step toward the corner.

"Who's there?"

She reached out to the light switch.

Click.

The hallway flooded with yellow light.

The figure vanished.

It was just coats. Just wool and canvas hanging on wooden pegs.

Emily let out a breath she didn't know she was holding.

"You're going crazy, Em," she whispered. "City nerves before you even get to the city."

She walked back to the kitchen.

But as she passed the shrine, she glanced at the Virgin one last time.

The statue hadn't moved.

But the votive candle...

It was out.

A thin trail of grey smoke curled up from the black wick.

There was no draft in the hall.

Emily stared at the smoke.

It smelled of wax.

And sulfur.

"Emily!" her father's voice called from the porch. "Car's loaded!"

Emily jumped.

"Coming, Daddy!"

She grabbed her bag. She didn't relight the candle.

She walked out of the house, into the bright September sun.

But the cold spot in the center of her chest didn't go away.

It felt like she had swallowed a piece of ice that wouldn't melt.

She hugged her mother on the porch. Maria felt small, fragile.

"Be good, Em," Maria whispered into her ear. "Say your prayers. Every night. Don't forget."

"I won't, Mama."

"And wear your medal. The St. Benedict medal."

"I have it on."

Emily touched the small silver chain around her neck.

Her father, Nathaniel, was waiting by the battered Ford station wagon. He looked uncomfortable in his Sunday shirt.

"Ready, princess?" he asked. His voice was gruff, hiding the fact that he was breaking inside.

"Ready," Emily lied.

She got into the car. The seat vinyl was hot from the sun.

As they drove down the long dirt driveway, dust billowing behind them like a smoke screen, Emily looked back.

The farmhouse looked small against the vast, grey sky. A wooden island in a sea of dying corn.

A crow was sitting on the fence post at the end of the drive.

It watched the car pass.

It didn't fly away.

It opened its beak and cawed.

A harsh, grating sound that sounded like metal tearing.

Emily shivered.

"Cold?" her father asked, glancing in the rearview mirror.

"Just... excited," Emily said.

But she wasn't looking at the road ahead.

She was looking at the house.

At the upstairs window. Her bedroom window.

The curtains were closed.

But she saw them move.

Just a twitch. As if someone was standing there, watching her leave.

"Goodbye," she whispered.

But the word felt wrong.

It didn't feel like she was leaving.

It felt like she was being sent.

Like a lamb being sent to market.

Or a soldier being sent to the front lines of a war she didn't even know existed.

CHAPTER 8: CAMPUS

The University was loud.

That was Emily's first impression. It was a constant, physical assault of noise. Cars honking, buses hissing, music thumping from dorm windows, construction jackhammers rattling the pavement.

It was a wall of sound that drowned out the silence of the farm.

And Emily loved it.

She loved the anonymity of it. In the noise, she couldn't hear the wind scratching at the walls. In the crowd, she couldn't feel the eyes watching her.

Her dorm room was a shoebox on the third floor of Johnson Hall. Cinderblock walls painted a pale, institutional yellow. Two beds. Two desks. One window that looked out onto a brick wall.

It was the most beautiful place she had ever seen.

It was hers.

Her roommate was a girl named Alice.

Alice was everything Emily was not. She was from Chicago. She had short, spiky hair dyed a color that didn't occur in nature—a dark, bruised plum. She wore oversized sweaters that smelled of clove cigarettes and patchouli.

"You're a virgin, right?" Alice asked within five minutes of meeting her. She was unpacking a crate of vinyl records. *The Ramones. Patti Smith. The Sex Pistols.*

Emily blushed, turning red from her neck to her hairline. She was folding her underwear into neat, square piles.

"Is it that obvious?"

Alice laughed. It was a smoky, worldly sound. "Honey, you have a crucifix on your wall, you fold your panties like origami, and you're wearing a cardigan in September. It's adorable."

Alice lit a cigarette, blowing the smoke out the open window. "Don't worry. We'll corrupt you by Thanksgiving. I'll have you drinking cheap wine and listening to punk rock in no time."

Emily laughed. It felt good to laugh.

"I like wine," she said bravely.

"Communion wine doesn't count," Alice said, winking.

The first month was a blur of joy.

Classes. Philosophy 101. Literature. Anthropology.

Emily sat in the front row. She took notes in her precise, cursive handwriting. She raised her hand. She argued about Kant and Descartes.

She walked through the quad in the autumn sunlight, kicking leaves that crunched satisfyingly under her boots.

She felt... normal.

She felt like a student. Not a farm girl. Not a "sensitive." Just a girl.

It was a Tuesday in late October when the shadow returned.

Emily was studying in the library. The "stacks"—the deep, silent rows of books in the basement.

It was late. 10:00 PM. The library was closing soon.

She was reading *The Brothers Karamazov*.

The air in the basement was cool and smelled of old paper and dust.

Scritch.

A sound from the next aisle.

Emily looked up.

"Hello?"

Silence.

Just the hum of the fluorescent lights.

Scritch. Scritch.

Like a fingernail dragging across a book spine. Or a claw testing the fabric of reality.

Emily stood up. She walked to the end of the aisle and looked down the row.

Empty.

Just rows and rows of books.

But the air...

It smelled different here.

Not paper.

It smelled wet. Like a dog that had come in from the rain. And something else.

Sulfur.

Faint, but there. The smell of a match.

"Is someone there?" she called out.

The lights flickered.

Buzz-click. Buzz-click.

For a second, the aisle went dark.

When the lights buzzed back on, Emily saw it.

At the far end of the row.

A book was on the floor.

It hadn't been there a second ago.

Emily walked toward it. Her footsteps echoed on the linoleum. *Clack. Clack.*

She knelt down.

It was a book on theology. *The Problem of Evil.*

It was open.

Face down.

As if someone had thrown it.

Emily reached out to pick it up.

The air grew cold. Freezing. Her breath puffed out in a white cloud.

She touched the book.

It was ice cold.

She snatched her hand back.

"Okay," she whispered. "Okay, that's creepy. I'm leaving."

She grabbed her bag and walked quickly to the stairs. She didn't run. She refused to run.

It's just a draft. It's just old pipes.

She burst out of the library doors and into the night.

The fog had rolled in off the lake. It was thick, white, and cold. It swallowed the streetlights, turning them into glowing, hazy orbs.

Emily wrapped her scarf tighter around her neck.

She took the shortcut through the park.

It was a path lined with old oak trees. In the day, it was beautiful. At night, in the fog, it looked like a tunnel into nowhere.

Crunch. Crunch.

Footsteps behind her.

Heavy. Deliberate.

Emily stopped.

The footsteps stopped.

She turned around.

"Alice?"

The fog swirled. Grey shapes dancing in the mist.

No answer.

Emily turned and walked faster.

Crunch. Crunch. Crunch.

The footsteps matched her pace. But they sounded... wet. *Slap. Slap.* Like bare feet on wet pavement.

Emily started to run.

The footsteps ran too.

SLAP. SLAP. SLAP.

Fast. Inhumanly fast. Closing the distance.

Emily burst out of the park and onto the lit street of the dorms.

She grabbed a lamppost, gasping for breath, her chest heaving.

She looked back at the park entrance.

The fog was a wall of white.

There was no one there.

But at the edge of the light... just where the darkness began...

She saw a shape.

A tall, thin shape.

It wasn't a student. It was too tall. Seven feet tall.

It was wearing a long coat. And a hat.

It raised a hand.

The fingers were too long. They looked like jointed twigs.

It waved.

A slow, mocking wave.

I see you, Emily.

Emily turned and ran to her dorm. She didn't stop until she was inside the lobby, under the harsh glare of the security lights.

She ran up the stairs to the third floor.

She unlocked her door and slammed it shut. She threw the deadbolt.

Alice was on her bed, reading a magazine. She looked up, startled.

"Whoa, killer," Alice said. "What's chasing you? A frat boy?"

Emily leaned against the door, sliding down until she hit the floor. She was shaking.

"Nothing," she gasped. "Just... a creep in the park."

"City life," Alice said, rolling her eyes. "Get some pepper spray. Or a whistle."

Emily nodded.

"Yeah. Pepper spray."

But she knew pepper spray wouldn't help.

She looked at the window. The fog was pressing against the glass like a face.

The thing in the park didn't have eyes.

She had seen its face in the flash of the streetlamp.

It had empty sockets filled with black fire.

And it knew where she lived.

It had followed her from the farm.

It had followed her to the library.

And now, it was outside her window.

Waiting for the lights to go out.